

University of Michigan

Essay #1 (Required for all applicants.)

Everyone belongs to many different communities and/or groups defined by (among other things) shared geography, religion, ethnicity, income, cuisine, interest, race, ideology, or intellectual heritage. Choose one of the communities to which you belong, and describe that community and your place within it. * 300 (584)

v3 - 299

In my super unbiased opinion, the altos are the best section in the choir; after all, we were the first to put up a section photo, adorned with crazy hats and sunnies, on the performing arts bulletin. Droning on the same note for four pages, or skipping around two octaves in one measure, the alto gives a piece of music strength and heart.

I became known as a “reliable singer” by my directors and section. Lowerclassmen would ask me for help, I’d give starting pitches to the altos, and I’d help frantic classmates practice as we walked to class.

When I got into our advanced choir, Chamber Singers, and was surrounded by music theory geniuses, I was intimidated--but so was everyone else. Our jazz student director composed three harmony lines to a new piece in real-time. A sophomore sightread our hardest piece of music perfectly on the first try. But we all memorize new pieces in two nights, sight-sing complicated pieces as warmups, and meet the surprisingly time-consuming expectations of Zoom choir.

From our shared passion for music, I found more motivation to practice in my free time, to be the best musician I could be. I became an alto section leader in our choral leadership team. I’ve been part of memorable performances and pieces, like the standing-ovation-worthy performance of Lift Every Voice, composed by our own Dr. Robles, that we performed in New York.

Whenever I watch the choir-themed TikToks my roommate and I filmed at three AM on our New York tour, I remember how preparing for our unforgettable spotlight performance at Carnegie Hall was more than just music-making. Although the sight of burgundy chairs atop carpeted risers will forever be ingrained in my brain, so will the faces and voices of the people sitting on them.

v2 - 415

There’s something about solo-singing a page of music that is terrifying and unifying. Based on the color of our voices, we are meticulously placed in a specific seat in “our” voice section for the purpose of creating a collective sound that mimics a single voice.

In my super unbiased opinion, the altos are the best section; after all, we were the first to put up a section photo, crazy hats and sunnies adorned, on the performing arts bulletin. Droning on the same note for four pages, or skipping around two octaves in one measure, the alto gives a piece of music strength and heart. I became known as a “reliable singer” by my directors and section. Lowerclassmen would ask me for help, I’d give starting pitches to the altos, and I’d help frantic classmates practice as we walked to class.

When it came time to audition for Chamber Singers, a group only a select few freshmen got into every year, I deepened my understanding of music theory, presented a strong front at my audition despite my nervousness, and accepted the spot I was granted with a heart full of gratitude.

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Our shared passion for music energized my efforts to practice in my free time. I found motivation to be my best, not only to become a better musician and vocalist, things that would allow me to become an alto section leader in our choral leadership team, but to help my friends remember unforgettable performances and pieces, like the standing-ovation-worthy performance of Lift Every Voice composed by our very own Dr. Robles that we performed in New York.

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v1

There's something about solo-singing a page of *sheet* music that is so *simultaneously* terrifying and unifying. Based on the *timbre* and color of our voices, we are *each* meticulously placed in a specific seat in "our" voice section for the *sole* purpose of creating a collective sound that mimics a single voice.

Although, as a young choir student, I prided myself on being a soprano, always singing the melody and having the most elegant[prettiest?] parts, I thank Ms. Burtchaell for dubbing me an alto. In my super unbiased opinion, we are the best section; after all, we were the first to put up[post] a section photo, crazy hats and sunnies adorned, on the performing arts bulletin.

Droning on the same note for four pages or skipping around two octaves in one measure, our staff riddled with accidentals and naturals, the alto gives a piece of music strength and heart. I *become[became]* known as a "reliable singer" by my directors and section. Lowerclassmen would ask me for help, I'd give starting pitches to the altos, and I'd help frantic classmates practice as we walked to class.

I began to realize there was more to being in an ensemble than just "knowing" my part. I'd been able to memorize and learn pieces throughout my ten years of choir, but the first time I felt I really challenged myself was auditioning for Chamber Singers, a group only a select few freshmen got into every year. Grabbing onto the encouragement of altos that made it before me, I deepened my understanding of music theory, presented a strong front at my audition despite my nervousness, and accepted the spot I was granted with a heart full of gratitude.

Still, being surrounded by vocal and music theory geniuses at my school, I was intimidated, until I realized, so was everyone else. While our jazz student director composed three harmony lines to a new piece in real-time, and a new sophomore sightread our hardest piece of music perfectly on the first try, we all find ourselves memorizing new pieces in two nights, sight-singing complicated pieces as warmups, and meeting the surprisingly time-consuming expectations of Zoom choir.

Different than middle school choir, where we went to festivals to compete, Chamber Singers took competition out of the picture while still fueling our drive. Yes, travel competitions had been fun: belting out Disney songs and ironically covering our classical pieces as pop songs on boats and buses. But, when Chambers took the competition aspect out of festivals, it felt more like a celebration of our passion for music.

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Whenever I get a text from a graduated Chamber member forwarding me the choir-themed TikToks my roommate and I filmed at three am on our New York tour, I'm reminded of how preparing for our unforgettable spotlight performance at Carnegie Hall was more than just music-making. Although the sight of burgundy chairs atop carpeted risers will forever be ingrained in my brain, so will the faces and voices of the people sitting on them.

v0

There's something about solo-singing a page of sheet music that is so simultaneously terrifying and unifying. Based on the timbre and color of our voices, we are each meticulously placed in a specific seat in "our" voice section for the sole purpose of creating a collective sound that mimics a single voice.

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Essay #2 (Required for all applicants.)

Describe the unique qualities that attract you to the specific undergraduate College or School (including preferred admission and dual degree programs) to which you are applying at the University of Michigan. How would that curriculum support your interests? * 550

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Transferring from a small public school deep in the Valley to a K-8th school overlooking LA for highly gifted students was like switching worlds. Their “sponsored by Apple” logo brandished the entrance to the school as a personal MacBook awaited me inside my new 4th-grade classroom. Opening up my laptop at home for the first time, I was instantly mesmerized by the ability to color-code folders on my desktop and “inspect element” on web pages. Although I started with Lego Robotics, basic HTML, and ID Tech camps for Scratch, the programming classes I began taking in eighth grade helped me internalize just how much I could accomplish with a laptop. Formally learning Java in computer science classes, I applied my learned skills to branch out to new languages; XCode for app development at my first Hackathon, which I further explored in the Intro to Mobile Application Development course at Harvard Secondary Summer School; Unity at my first Game Jam; and HTML, CSS, and Javascript, which I learned on the job as a Product Design Intern at an AI company, GumGum, and implemented at my junior year hackathon. We created a website, winning third place, that integrated Spotify’s Web API.

Computer science soon transcended my programming classes. In ninth grade biology, I learned about computational biology and the intersections between machine learning, gene editing, and bioinformatics. As we talked about the gene-editing technology, CRISPR, we also delved into the ethicality behind designer babies. I became enchanted by the ethical debates surrounding research and AI and joined our high school’s Ethics Bowl Team to engage in more of these discussions and learn to logically present my thoughts.

One of the first things that attracted me to U-Mich’s Computer Science major was its focus on practical applications of computer science and programming in addition to a theoretical computer science education. Even in the 100 and 200 level courses, where you would expect to see generic Introduction to CS courses, Michigan has both fundamental skills courses, like Computer Science Pragmatics which focuses on programming tools and environments, *and* courses like Thriving in a Digital World (EECS 101) which puts a focus on practical programming, allowing students explore computer science outside of theory and syntax by creating and designing functional mobile applications.

Being a computer science student for the last five years, I’ve realized how different programming in a classroom is to programming in a professional or personal setting. But, Michigan does a great job of trying to bridge that gap by offering courses like EECS 281, System Design of a Search Engine, and EECS 44, connecting real-life applications of computer science with teachable, learnable material. Even commonly theoretical courses, like machine learning, emphasize their practical aspects; Introduction to Machine Learning teaches theory as well as the implementation of ML algorithms into real-world applications.

The practicality of Michigan’s CS offerings is highly appealing because I can imagine confidently entering the workforce having experience writing applications or even creating my own computer products as a student at Michigan. As a previous hackathon competitor, seeing Michigan’s

semiannual hackathon MHacks winners' projects helped me envision the types of things I could create being a student there. With winners like Vitamin See, a web application; VR Piano, a virtual reality game; and Stock Wise, a machine learning-based program, Michigan's computer science department helps students take what they learn in the classroom to create tangible products and businesses in the span of 48 hours. Scrolling through MHack's six pages of over 100 project submissions excites and inspires me to continue learning and become a better programmer.

Aside from Michigan's unique approach to an undergraduate computer science curriculum, so many of the major's professors are awe-inspiring. It's intriguing to see professors like Steve Abney doing research in an interdisciplinary field melding humanities and stem together through computational linguistics. Additionally, I was compelled by Nikola Banovic's research on human-computer interaction, combining computer vision and programming with ethics. Machine learning and artificial intelligence, areas of computer science I've become increasingly interested in learning, are core parts of human-computer interaction in technology today which is why offerings like EECS 593, Human-Computer Interaction taught by Professor Banovic, interest me greatly.

Aside from my CS interests, Michigan is one of the few schools I've seen that offers such an extensive list of Music Production courses. As someone who wants to pursue music for fun, having options, like production courses and Acappella groups, to continue exploring my musical interests is important to me. It's also important to me that Michigan provides classes like "The Science Behind Sustainability" and has programs like Planet Blue since sustainability is something that is important for me personally and for others to learn the importance of. Finally, as someone that played club and school volleyball for 9 years, I'm so excited to be able to continue playing a sport that I love, just for fun, with the intramural sand volleyball team.